

# THE RULING OPPOSITION

Though an ally of the DPA coalition in the state, PMK founder S. Ramadoss is the Government's harshest critic



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■ By Peer Mohammed

**A**s a constituent of the DMK-led DPA Government of Tamil Nadu, PMK founder S. Ramadoss would be expected to have nothing but kind words for the 83-year-old DMK chief and Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi. But the reality is somewhat different. With 18 MLAs who occupy the ruling benches in the state Assembly, the PMK is a more vocal opposition than the AIADMK, the official Opposition party, and its leader, J. Jayalalithaa.

When Karunanidhi recently warned the PMK chief that "the aggressive opposition and criticism by the PMK might create tensions between the cadres of the two parties", the 68-year-old Ramadoss retorted: "The alliance with the DMK is nothing but an electoral agreement. That was over with the elections. We will be acting as a responsible Opposition."

That's no empty threat. Consider this: When the then former Union IT minister

Dayanidhi Maran proposed the idea of eviction of people from 140 villages to sell the land to private players for satellite development, Ramadoss forced Karunanidhi to abandon the idea the very next day. Then yielding to PMK's pressure the Government had to shift the expansion plan of the Chennai International Airport from its northern part to the less-populated southern part.

But it was on the issue of higher education that the differences came to the fore. When Ramadoss accused the DMK

**OLD EQUATIONS: Ramadoss is once again being wooed by Jayalalithaa**



regime of not controlling the 'exorbitant' cost of higher education, Karunanidhi asked for 'evidence'. Ramadoss ridiculed the demand for evidence and virtually taunted the Government by asking it to act in accordance with the 'Prohibition of Capitation Fee' passed by the Jayalalithaa-led AIADMK regime in 1992. Following sustained pressure from PMK, K. Ponmudi, minister for higher education, announced last week that the Government will take stern action against those private educational institutions which are overcharging.

It is not just on policy matters that PMK and DMK have been fighting. At a recent rally in support of the UPA presidential candidate Pratibha Patil in Chennai, Ramadoss was miffed at being asked to sit in a separate platform while Karunanidhi shared the dais with Patil.

Besides needling the coalition leader, PMK took up a week-long agitation against the Andhra Pradesh Government that is building a dam across river Palar. The